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Hate Speech on Twitter: Vox in the Catalan Parliamentary Elections

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ABSTRACT

The Spanish far-right Vox party ran for the first time as a candidate for the Catalan parliamentary elections in February 2021. This paper analyses the party's political discourse on Twitter during the Catalan parliamentary election campaign in order to assess whether the degree of dialectical confrontation of their messages can exceed the limits of democratic debate. The results reveal how this far-right party's inflammatory messages, which seek to insult its political opponents, ultimately foster an undemocratic environment that turns Vox's political rivals into its enemy, driving social polarisation and a discourse of hatred towards individuals defending other ideologies or parties. Ultimately, it is intended to add that political-ideological nuance for future research that surpasses traditional hate speech—such as those based on criteria such as race or sex—and the suitability of Twitter for the proliferation of the latter.

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Introduction

The germ of the far-right political party, Vox, dates to the summer of 2012, specifically to the reconversion.es platform. This group was formed by some historical members of the Partido Popular such as Alejo Vidal-Quadras, José Antonio Ortega Lara or Santiago Abascal, whose aim was to put an end to the State of Autonomies in Spain. This idea finally crystallised in the political party that saw the light of day at the end of 2013. However, their ideas did not translate into seats until the elections of April 28th, 2019. Six months later, following a repeat of the Spanish general elections, the party doubled its parliamentary presence, taking 15.09% of the vote and 52 seats, to become Spain's third political force. (BOE 2019).

Vox's ideology resembles that of other Western populist parties (Vox 2020; Ferreira 2019), espousing authoritarianism, family values, social conservatism and anti-feminism, as well as a national identity based on an anti-immigration dogma (with an anti-Muslim discourse) (Wodak 2017). Indeed, over and above its anti-immigration stance, Vox tailors its discourse around anti-Catalan nationalism as a central pillar (Bernárdez-Rodal, Requeijo Rey, and Franco 2020). Paradoxically, this position helped the political party to gain

notoriety and votes from the acceleration of the Catalan independence process in 2017. Several authors have considered this fact as one of the factors that made possible the arrival of Vox to the legislative chambers starting from the Andalusian elections of 2018 (Turnbull-Dugarte, Rama, and Santana 2020; Vampa 2020)

As is typical of far-right parties, Vox disseminates its populist stance through discursive strategies on social media, which, unlike the legacy media, gives it direct contact with its supporters and potential voters. In fact, the party has official profiles on all the main social media platforms, which have all been studied previously: Twitter (Méndez-Santos 2020; Cheddadi 2020; Vázquez Barrio, Zabala, and V 2020; Luque Ortiz and Cano Alarcón 2021; Rebollo-Bueno 2022), Instagram (Aladro-Vico and Requeijo-Rey 2020; Bernárdez-Rodal, Requeijo Rey, and Franco 2020), Tik-tok (Gutiérrez-Sanz and Etura-Hernández 2021), YouTube (Rodríguez-Serrano, García-Catalán, and Martín-Núñez 2019) and Facebook (Belim 2020).

Twitter is a particularly representative platform where political debate drives polarisation (Bustos-Díaz and Capilla del Fresno 2013; Schuliaquer and Vommaro 2020). It is also a benchmark for interactive communication between citizens, parties and candidates (Holtz-Bacha 2013; Lingardi et al. 2019; Maarek 2014). Vox uses Twitter as a vessel for much of its communication strategy (Cea-Esteruelas 2020). Manuel Mariscal, a Vox MP in the Congress of Deputies, who oversees the party's digital strategy, recently stated, "The media is no longer trusted ... We are becoming our own communication channel" (Vázquez-Barrio 2021, 128).

It comes as no surprise, therefore, that Twitter has been a frequent research subject in online political discourse, which has led to different methodological proposals, from rhetoric (Gutiérrez-Sanz 2016) to hate speech (Miró-Llinares 2016), and far-right hate speech in tweets from various countries (Boomgaarden and Vliegenthart 2007; Çöltekin 2020; Jaki and De Smedt 2019; Okky-Ibrohim and Budy 2019; Sanguinetti et al. 2018; Shehaj, Shin, and Inglehart 2021).

Undoubtedly, the proliferation of offensive content and hate speech in the digital environment provides a fertile ground for research (Paz, Montero, and Moreno 2020), as shown in the many papers on this phenomenon. Such contributions range from the presence of hate speech on the Internet and social media (Cammaerts 2009; Domingo et al. 2008 or Ekman 2019), and specifically on Twitter itself (Burnap and Williams 2015; Ott 2017), Facebook (Farkas, Schou and Neumayer 2018; Kus 2016), YouTube (Murthy and Sharma 2019), the online press (Harlow 2015), and even newsgames (Gómez-Quintero, Aguerri, and Gimeno-Monterde 2021). The topics of these studies are diverse and have addressed racist discourse (Klein 2012), xenophobic discourse (Yamaguchi 2013), Islamophobia (Awan 2016) or homophobia (Mrs̃ević 2013), in addition to multidisciplinary approaches on the socio-political consequences of these messages on vulnerable groups and collectives (Gómez-Quintero, Aguerri, and Gimeno-Monterde 2021) and the emergence of new phenomena such as the so-called "crypto-hate speech" which is semantically constructed in a similar way to traditional hate speech and is becoming increasingly prevalent (Herrero et al 2022; Reguero, Berdón and Herrero 2023).

To consider the state of the question, we need to present a more comprehensive view of Vox and its social media activity, particularly regarding offensive communication that contributes to the growing discourse of hatred in society (Jones and Trice 2020). Hence, we examine Vox's political discourse on Twitter by analysing all the tweets posted on the

platform by a relevant sample of Vox's leadership during its first campaign for the Catalan parliamentary elections, held between 29 January and 14 February 2021 with the following objectives:

- To check whether the tweets of this political formation constitute a political discourse directed towards other political parties or ideologies.
- To raise the debate on whether this type of messages should be considered as hate speech and, therefore, be criminally punished.

To this end, we formulated the following research questions:

- How did Vox articulate its discourse on Twitter during the Catalan election campaign? (Language, activity by users, frequency of posting, devices used or the formal elements of the tweets)
- Is offensive communication towards other parties a key element in its messages?
- Is offensive discourse an essential component for this party in an electoral context?
- What linguistic elements (terms, hashtags, semantic constructions) constitute this dynamic of offensive discourse?

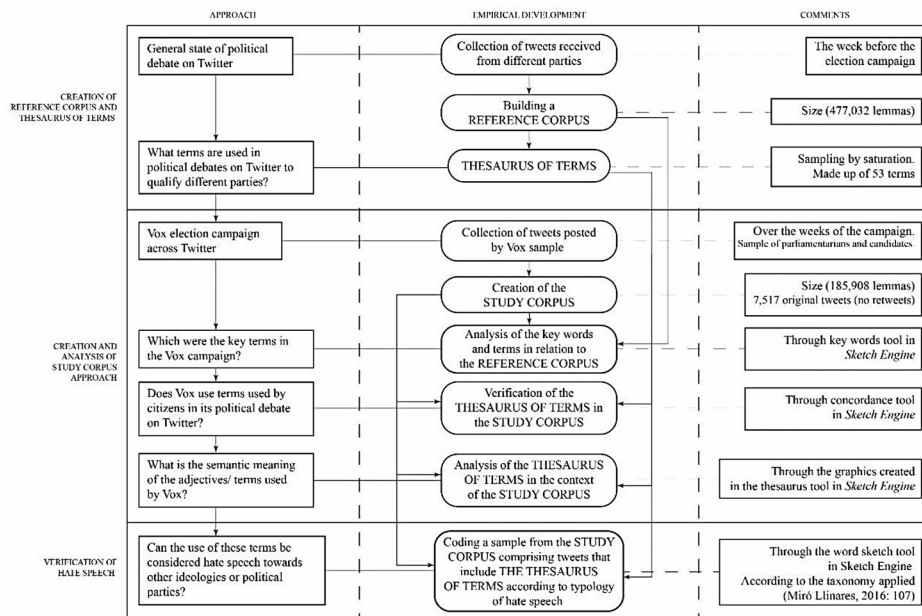
This research is based on the hypothesis that this type of message fosters an atmosphere so tense that it moves away from the confrontation of ideas that is necessary in any democracy.

Methodological Proposal

Our paper analyses all the messages posted on the social media platform Twitter by a relevant sample of Vox's representatives during the election campaign to the Catalan regional parliament, which took place between 29 January and 14 February 2021. Our research was based on the methodological principle proposed by Richard Rogers of the University of Amsterdam that encourages researchers to consider the Internet as a source of social and cultural information for which specific approaches are needed for its study (2013). Following this paradigm, we developed a triangulation method combining quantitative content analysis and linguistic corpus analysis (see Table 1), a combination that, applied in previous research (Kress and Van Leeuwen 2001), has demonstrated its relevance in yielding meaningful results.

Quantitative content analysis can be used to expose hidden meanings in messages by yielding general results (Igartua and Humanes 2004), although these often require complementary techniques to gain a deeper insight. For discourse analysis research, corpus linguistics facilitates the semantic interpretation of the content of texts, which is beyond the scope of content analysis. Further, technological breakthroughs in linguistics have provided the science with computer tools that can systematically process units of analysis, thus avoiding the biases inherent in the analysis of opinionative discourses. For the purpose of our study, we used the Sketch Engine tool, which has been previously validated (Izquierdo-Alegría 2018; Kutter and Kantner 2012; Touri and Koteyko 2014).

We focused on the personal Twitter accounts of politicians who are members of Vox and excluded those of the party's organisation, as the tweets from the latter might be

Table 1. Methodological outline.

Note: Source: own elaboration

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less spontaneous and subordinated to a specific strategy, which would not be representative of the political debate “on the front line”. The sampling was stratified according to two population groups: Vox MPs of the lower house of the Spanish Parliament (the Congress of Deputies) and candidates for the 2021 Catalan parliamentary elections. We selected the two strata that wielded the most significant influence on social media, i.e., politicians with the most followers and inclusions in Twitter lists. To avoid profiles using unethical tactics to obtain followers, such as the follow-unfollow technique¹, we considered the number of profiles followed by these accounts. The final sample comprised 37 personal profiles: 23 Spanish MPs and 14 candidates for the Generalitat, the Catalan regional government (see Appendix 1).

We collected all the tweets posted by the sample during the election campaign to the Catalan parliament using Text Mining techniques that helped us access and explore the tweets semi-automatically. The data-mining environment was initiated following a request for a Twitter API, with which we downloaded massive amounts of information following R programming language parameters. Once this step was completed, we downloaded the sample of tweets on 4, 10 and 17 February, resulting in a universe of 7,517 messages. The dates for downloading the tweets were chosen to be able to collect all the messages of the campaign, taking into account the time restrictions set by the Twitter API. Retweets and quoted tweets were included in the download, making up the raw sample. From the total of 87 variables downloaded by the Twitter API, the following were selected for analysis: author of the tweet, day and time of publication, device from which it was sent, location, description that appeared in the personal account of the author of each post, followers and followees, link and text of the tweet.

We performed the content analysis using the VOSON Dashboard from RStudio, which provided information on the ratio of messages per day and time slot, platform of origin, type of content or discursive trends of the sample of politicians, among others, allowing us to study the behaviour patterns of the Twitter profiles under study. Once the content analysis was completed, we began the linguistic analysis; in other words, we went “from form to substance”.

The first step to delve deeper into the semantics of the messages required the building of a reference corpus with which we would compare the study corpus of Vox’s tweets. However, although Sketch Engine has a wide range of text corpora (in several languages, with pieces from a wide range of origins), it does not include a corpus on “political language on social media”. Thus, we again used data mining to build our own reference corpus, this time collecting all the messages from the Twitter accounts of Spain’s principal statewide political parties (PSOE, PP, Vox, Unidas Podemos and Ciudadanos) that were posted one week before the launch of the Catalan election campaign. In this way, we obtained a linguistic corpus exclusively of messages directly related to our study in terms of their origin and subject matter, i.e., with the features of a campaign or pre-campaign context where not only political proposals but also arguments aimed at contradicting and even discrediting the rival were to be expected. With this procedure we obtained a reference corpus of 477,032 words with which we studied the 185,908 words of the study corpus.

The next step entailed finding terms relevant in the dissemination of hate speech towards an opposing political ideology, which would be analysed in the study corpus, consisting of only Vox’s tweets made during its election campaign. These lemmas were compiled with the Thesaurus tool, which automatically generates a list of synonyms identified by the Sketch Engine algorithm as belonging to similar semantic fields. Subsequently, we used the saturation sampling method to obtain the highest number of terms and synonyms, totalling 53 key words. With these key words and the study corpus containing all the tweets in the sample, we used Sketch Engine tools to check for the existence and semantic importance of political-ideological hate speech in Vox’s first parliamentary election campaign in Catalonia. After this, taking as our reference the extended taxonomy of violent communication and hate speech proposed by Miró-Llinares (2016), we randomly sampled messages that were susceptible of being used against opposing political ideologies to confirm or reject the existence of this type of discourse.

Results

Vox’s Twitter Activity in the run-up to the Catalan Regional Parliamentary Elections

Social media are a crucial component of Vox’s campaign strategy (Cheddadi 2020; Méndez-Santos 2020). Therefore, to understand the party’s online discourse, we analysed the development of Vox’s election campaign on Twitter from the point of view of form, giving us a snapshot of the communicative strategy deployed.

A first interesting fact is that Vox’s electoral campaign strategy on Twitter in the elections to the Catalan Parliament of 2021 stands out for its posts in Spanish (98.04% of its posts were in Spanish, 1.32% in Catalan and 0.57% in English). The messages tweeted

from the accounts throughout the election campaign totalled 7,517 tweets, most of them posted by the following Vox party members: José Ramírez del Río ² (11.24%), Víctor Sánchez del Real³ (10.74%), Iván Espinosa de los Monteros⁴ (6.33%), Macarena Olona⁵ (5.44%) and Cristina Esteban Calonje⁶ (5.14%). None of these Vox MPs was running as candidates, yet their tweets made up most of the posts during the campaign. Indeed, Spanish MPs, who enjoy greater media exposure and have better-developed networks of influence than do the candidates for the Catalan Generalitat, played a pivotal role in the campaign. Moreover, as elected politicians, their personal Twitter accounts may also be managed by the party's communication team, increasing the number of tweets from these profiles.

Figure 1 shows an uneven distribution of posts tweeted during the period under study. In this regard, three phases are identifiable, the first phase corresponding to the start of the campaign (from 29 January to 5 February), which saw an average of 427.3 tweets, following a downward trend from 28 January. The second phase spans the middle of the campaign (from 6 to 9 February), when an upward trend in posts was observed, averaging 535.25 tweets and peaking at 614 on 7 February. Thereafter, the number of tweets posts declined until the third phase (from 10 to 14 February), when the tweets averaged 193. Remarkably, the fall in the average number of tweets/frequency of tweets by Vox coincided with the release of a voting intention poll by the Sociological Research Centre⁷, predicting a good turnout for this party. This seems to explain why Vox eased up its inflammatory tweets, preferring to maintain a low profile rather than overkill its campaign.⁸

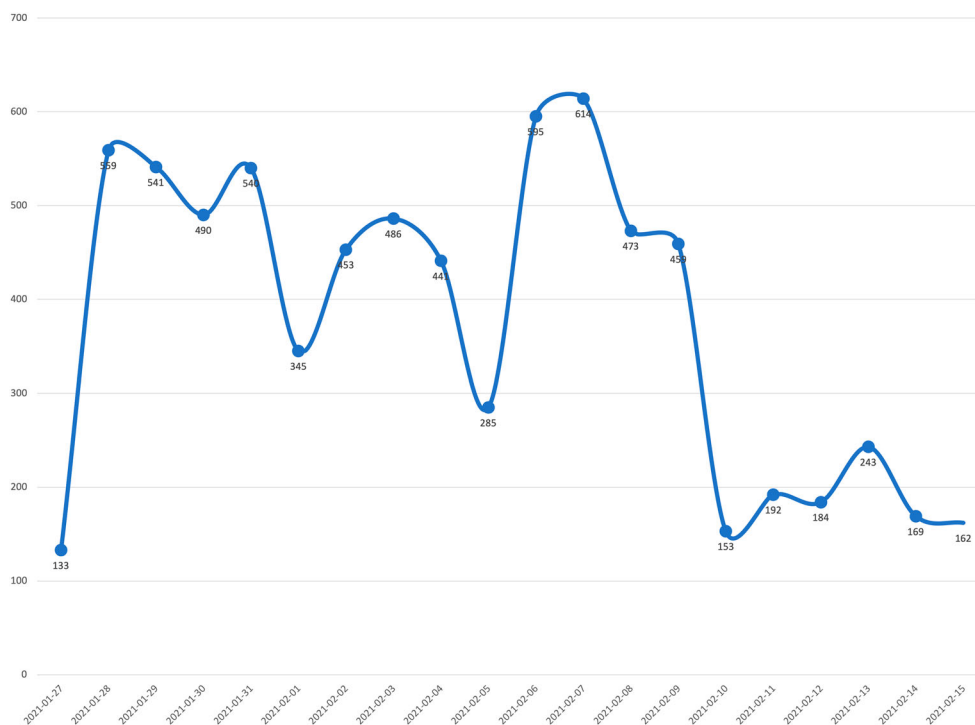


Figure 1. Tweets per day (27 January - 15 February 2021). Note: Source: own elaboration.

Most of the messages (88.88%) were tweeted from mobile devices (either phones or tablets), indicating that the campaign was mainly conducted on the go, with little prior planning and no use of messages programming mechanisms or tools. Likewise, 85.33% of the tweets included no hyperlink, meaning that Vox relied instead on the message itself to sway the electorate. The few tweets that did feature a link (14.66%) mainly mention other tweets sent within the platform itself, suggesting that Vox ran a highly “inbred” campaign, since Vox politicians’ tweets typically mention other party members. In other words, although 1,547 accounts were mentioned in the tweets, most of them occurred on an *ad hoc* basis as an isolated event (1,100 users are mentioned only once or twice). The real conversation on social media took place among members of Vox; thus, the account most mentioned (846 times) was that of the party itself (@vox_es), followed by Ignacio Garriga (@lgarrigavaz) with 704 mentions. Vox’s Congress of Deputies Twitter account (@Vox_Congreso) was mentioned 703 times, Iván Espinosa de los Monteros (@ivanedlm) 462, Macarena Olona (@Macarena_Olona) 409 and Javier Ortega Smith (@OrtegaSmith) 234.

Analysis of Language Corpora. Hate Speech and Offensive Communication towards Other Political Ideologies: An Electoral Weapon

The most frequently used hashtags in Vox’s tweets were its campaign slogan: #RecuperemosCataluña⁹ (with the variant #RecuperemosCataluna and a version in Catalan, #RecuperemCatalunya), which epitomises its ideological stance towards the Catalan institutions, run by pro-independence parties. Another central slogan was #SoloquedaVox¹⁰ (#SoloVox¹¹, #VoxExtremaNecesidad¹² and #AhoraTienesVox¹³), which emerged during the campaign. This is both a highly charged message and an attempt to discredit the other political parties taking part in elections. Vox presents itself as the only viable alternative to “take back” – or “recover” – a Catalonia that was “snatched away” by secessionism. Hashtags referring to the televised political debates during the campaign included #DebatTV3, #DebateCATrtve, #ObjetivoDebate, etc.

At the same time, Vox’s hashtags underscored discourses aimed at offending or denigrating specific groups or parties, chiefly those with a progressive leaning, portrayed as ignorant (#MatemáticasParaProgres¹⁴, MatemáticasParaPodemitas¹⁵ and #PeriodismoParaProgres¹⁶), as liars (#CastaACostaDeTuPasta)¹⁷ or as authoritarian (#BastaDeCensuraProgre).¹⁸ Vox also used its hashtags to lash out against other Spanish right-wing parties (#DerechitaMiserable)¹⁹, and to pour scorn on gender differences (#ElSexoNoSeElige)²⁰ or expressed blatant manifestations of racism (#StopIslamización). It can be corroborated that the main themes of Vox’s rhetoric are centralist ideological stance in Catalonia, as opposed to independentism and positioning based on its discourse against the main issues of confrontation with other parties (above all, with political forces on the left of the spectrum). Of note are the tweets that address the issue of gender identity and action on immigration.

The party’s official Twitter account was temporality suspended for incitement to hatred because of a tweet including several of the slogans analysed above: “They account for approximately 0.2% and are responsible for 93% of [crime] reports. They mainly come from the Maghreb. Catalonia is unanimous and complicit in turning a blind eye to imported crime. Only Vox is left! #StopIslamización”.²¹ We used random sampling to

classify the discourse of Vox tweets according to the categories of violent communication and hate speech in the taxonomy proposed by Miró-Llinares (2016) (Table 2).

Accordingly, in the “threat” group, for example, we found tweets such as: “The separatists funded the massive influx of Muslim immigrants to convert them into the “New Catalans’ and instil a republican zeal in them. They’re guilty of turning Gerona into a haven for jihadism. They will have us to contend with. #RecuperemosCataluña #StopIslamización” (Vox 2021). Some examples fall in the category of “incitement to commit a violent response”: “(...) He just gave the feminists of [Unidas Podemos] a good thrashing (...)” (Ramírez 2021) and “(...) Kick the squatter in the arse, but do it now (...)” (Olona 2021). These statements form part of a broader category that Miró Llinares associates with physical violence.

Table 2. Extended taxonomy of violent communication and hate speech.

PHYSICAL VIOLENCE		
DISCOURSE RELATED TO PHYSICAL HARM (DPH)	α Direct threat/ Induction to direct violence?	1. Threat 2. Induction 3. Provocation
	β Incitement to violence	4a. Incitement to commit a crime 4b. Incitement to commit a violent response
MORAL VIOLENCE		
Discourse that offends or causes moral harm	γ Offending the honour and/or personal dignity	5a. High degree of honour and/or personal dignity 5b. Low degree of honour and/ or personal dignity 6. Honour and/ or personal dignity
Discourse that offends or causes communal moral harm	δ Incitement to discrimination/hatred	7. Incitement to discrimination 8. Group humiliation 8a. Expression of ill will aimed at a group
	ε Offending collective sensibilities	9. “Schadenfreude” 10a. Expressions of bad taste (through conspiranoia) 10b. Expressions of extreme bad taste 10c. Colloquial expressions of bad taste 10d. Expressions of bad taste (through irony)

Note: Source: Miró-Llinares (2016, 107)

As for moral violence, Vox tweeted messages that can be classified in the category of “offending the honour and/or personal dignity”, such as in: “That the terrorist Otegi is going to campaign in Catalonia for ERC demonstrates the benefits of terrorism in the Basque Country (...)” (Alcaráz 2021). Other tweets are perceived as “incitement to discrimination”: “My talks with the PP always start with: Socialists out!” (Monasterio 2021) and “Hotels, shops, travel agencies, leisure halls and gyms closing, while the separatists who condemn them to ruin run amok. We must kick them out!” (Gallego 2021). Regarding “group humiliation” – although closer to anti-social or offensive speech – Vox also directed messages to its more ideologically distant political opponents: “It’s not possible! Is it true they really don’t learn? Today’s programme is #MatemáticasParaProgres Limited Edition!!!! But very “limited” ... to repeat the same nonsense thinking you’re attacking your guest when you agree with him! Will you explain it to him, please? I give in!” (Espinoza de los Monteros 2021). Vox also levelled criticism at the party ideologically closest to

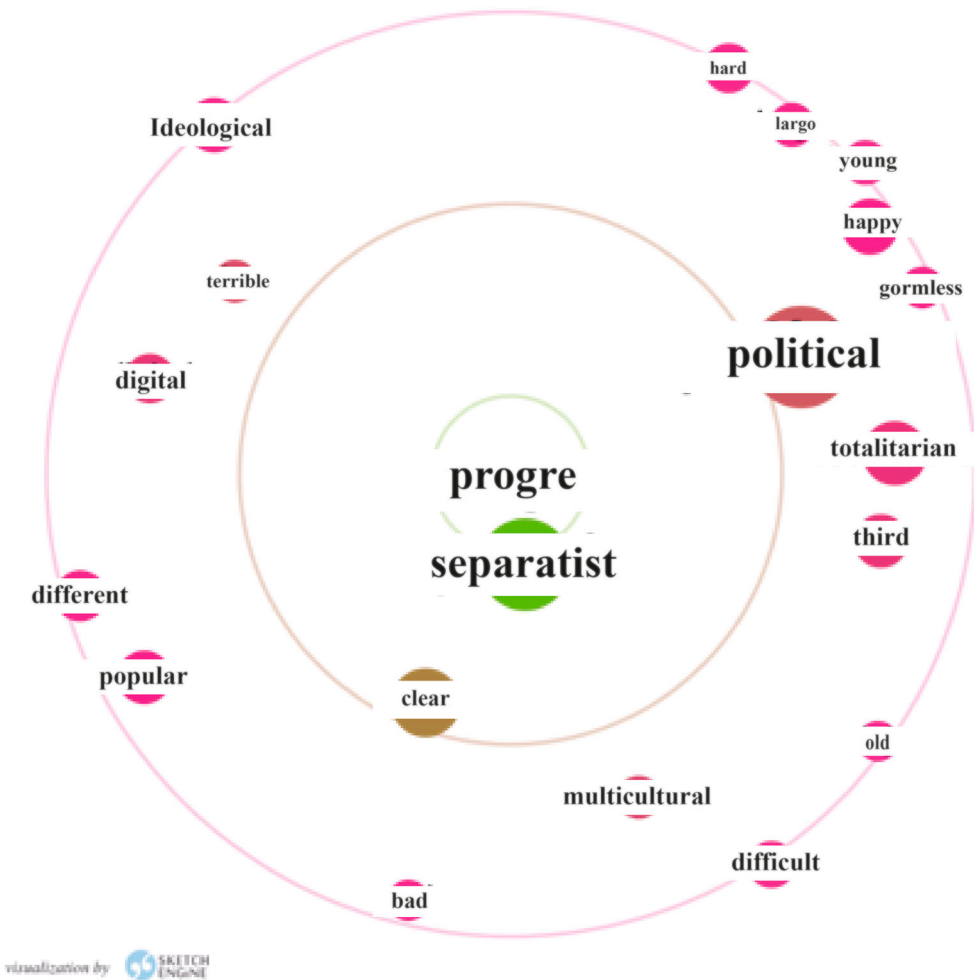


Figure 2. Semantic coincidence and relations between terms based on “progre”.²⁹ Note: Source: Sketch Engine.

it: “Not one more lesson or insult from the cowardly right-wing²² that behaves today like the wretched right-wing” (Vox Parliamentary Group 2021). On occasions, Vox resorted to invectives to express “ill will”: “And the separatist thugs know it. And they’re livid. Fuck them” (Del Pino 2021). In a similar vein, we found tweets seeking to offend collective sensibilities, which Miró Llinares classifies as “expressions in bad taste”: “Catalans are not forced to choose between those responsible for the separatist epidemic and those guilty of the current epidemic of death and ruin with the socially delinquent government. (...)” (Abascal 2021), “Where are those who feel indignant at the PONYTAILED RAT²³?” (Olona 2021) and “(...) the feminism of whinging and handouts. Feminism is about standing up to the secessionist rats [and waving] the Spanish flag in Olot” (Guaita 2021).

As for the messages targeting other parliamentary ideologies or parties, we observed the uses of certain verbs, nouns and adjectives in Vox’s offensive, in its anti-social or derisive messages directed its political adversary, understood as the enemy. The verbs that most frequently appeared in the tweets posted by Vox politicians and its candidates to the Catalan parliament were “recover”, or “take back”, and “defend”. These verbs, the

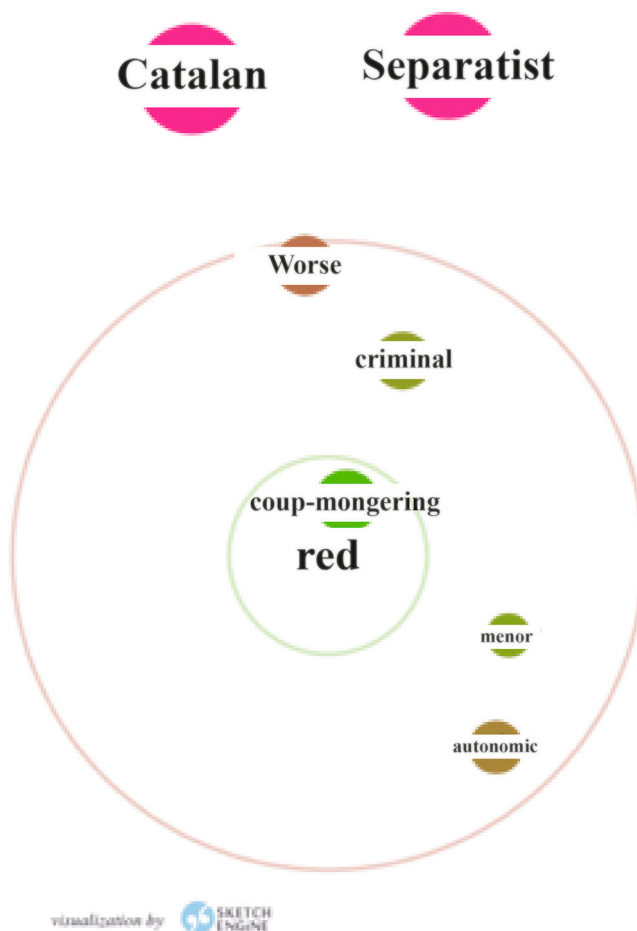


Figure 3. Semantic coincidence and relations between terms based on “red”. Note: Source: Sketch Engine.

first two used on 348 and the third on 332 occasions, provided an ideal link to its main campaign slogan: #RecuperemosCataluña. This somewhat combative call to action brings to mind previous speeches by Vox, such as the “Reconquista” of Andalusia or the “España Viva” campaign for the 2018 parliamentary elections in that autonomous region (García-Sanjuán 2020). In turn, although less frequent, these verbs stand in contrast to the victim complex discourse typical of fascist movements.²⁴ The use of verbs like “attack”, “harm”, or “insult” (75 mentions for the three)²⁵, “silence” (72) or “censor” or “censure” (39) portray Vox as a political party that is harassed and even persecuted. This may be better understood in the light of several incidents that put Vox at the centre of a dispute over reported assaults on the party during the campaign (ABC 2021).

The adjectives deployed by Vox are even more illustrative. Among the most frequent are “separatist” (211) and “Spanish” (147), somewhat predictable terminology given the political climate of identity and separatism in Catalonia (Clua-i-Fainé 2014). Other similar terms included “illegal” (153), “totalitarian” (66) or “coup-mongering” (55), which

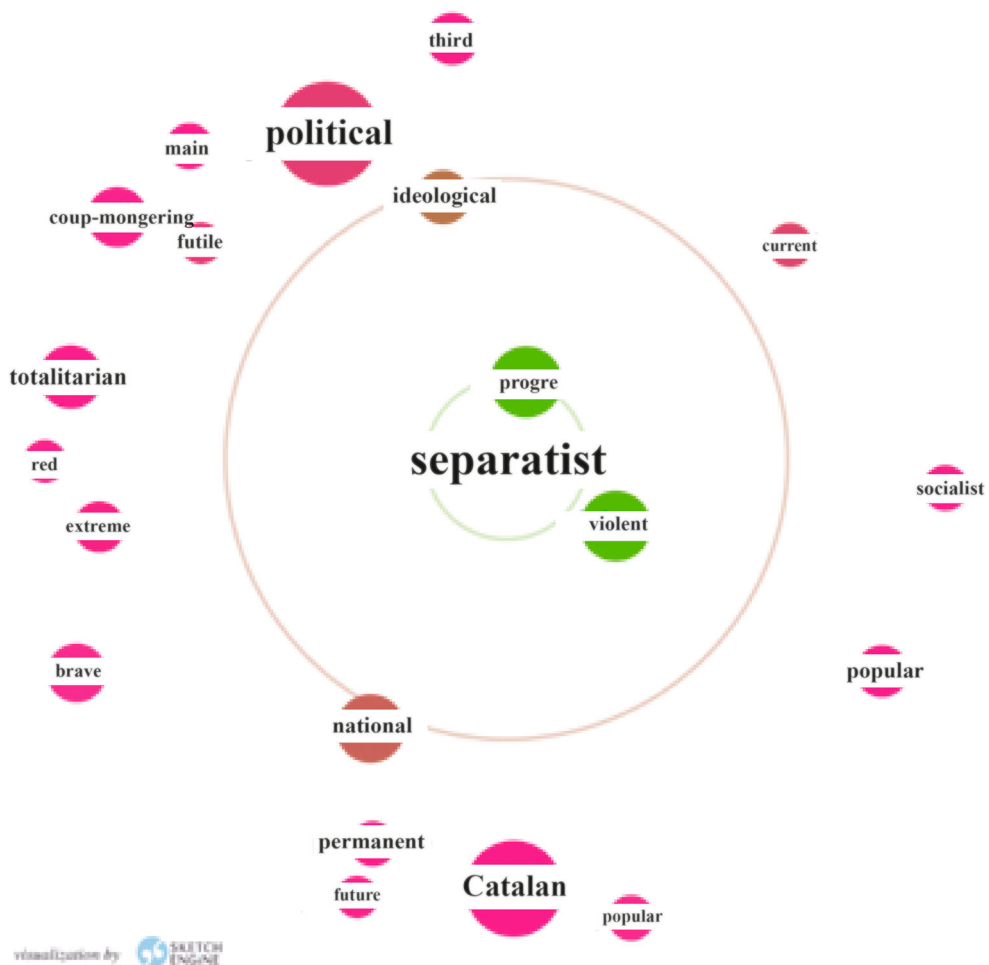


Figure 4. Semantic coincidence and relations between terms based on “separatist”. Note: Source: Sketch Engine.

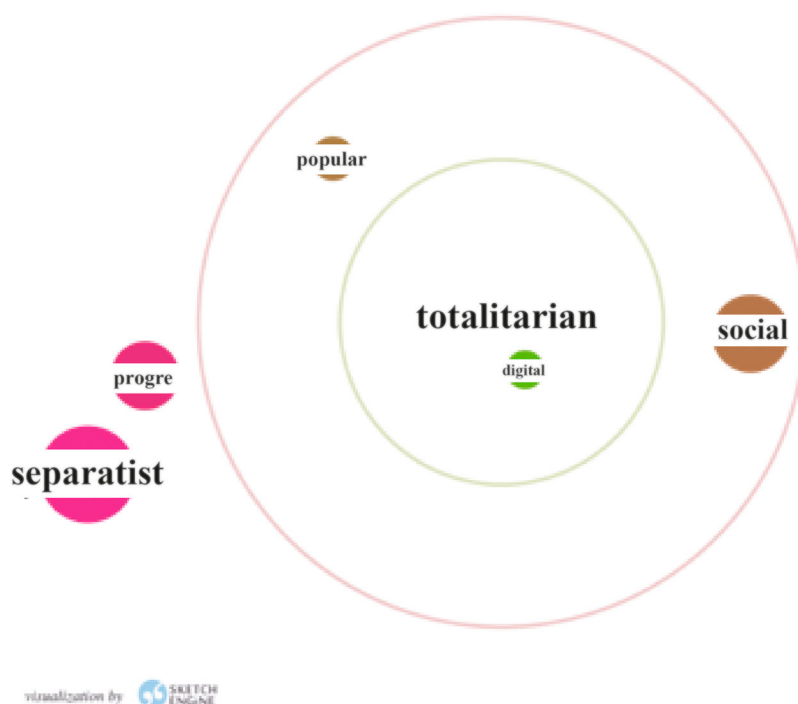


Figure 5. Semantic coincidence and relations between terms based on “totalitarian”. Note: Source: Sketch Engine.

offer an enlightening nuance, as does “nationalist” or “pro-separatist”, both of which were conspicuously absent in Vox’s campaign. Thus, we again observe a virulent discourse reiterating the idea of something having been usurped that must be “taken back” or “restored”, with no consideration for other political and ideological tendencies in both the Spanish and the regional parliaments, in this case, the Catalan parliament. Likewise, among specific terms denoting a highly ideological component, “*progre*” (96) was the one mentioned most tweeted, followed by socialist (19), fascist (18) and racist (17). We will later have recourse to these words in context.

Moreover, many of these adjectives featured in messages that seek to discredit. Noteworthy among them are “separatist Mafia” (75), “Coups-mongering Generalidad” (21), or “*progre* consensus” (26). The same is true of “migratory invasion” (53) and “Islamisation of Catalonia” (26), both of which can be defined as discrimination and hate speech. Indeed, the hashtag #StopIslamización is blatant hate speech and prosecutable as such.

Similarly, it is worth noting that such discourse, one tier above violent communication, was driven by the ideological factor and an evident climate of political and social polarisation. Figure 2 provides some examples of these.

Progre, which features prominently in today’s political lexicon and is currently a hot topic of debate in the media²⁶, is used colloquially to refer to a person who defends or advocates progressive ideas. However, as mentioned above, Vox’s tweets attribute an altogether different meaning to this term. As Figure 2 shows, *progre* belongs in the

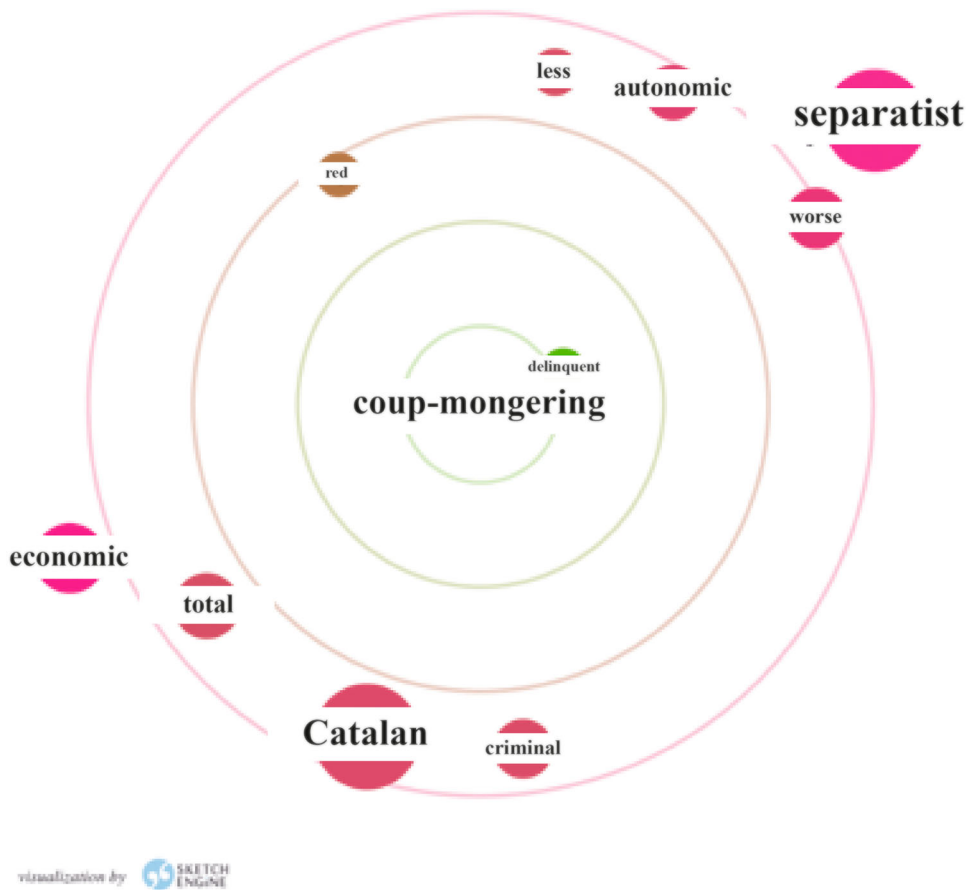


Figure 6. Semantic coincidence and relations between terms based on “coup-mongering”. Note: Source: Sketch Engine.

same semantic field as “separatist”, “totalitarian” or “multicultural”, words that in an ordinary context bear no relation to one another. Their association here responds to an intent to seek a common enemy, which also appears to explain another of Vox’s campaign slogans: #SoloquedaVox. Thus, the term *progre* becomes a “catch-all” for all the groups criticised by Vox in its political discourse, as Cheddadi (2020) noted. As we have seen, Vox also attacks conservative parties: “wretched right-wing”, mentioned 13 times, was one of the expressions that regularly appeared in Vox’s tweets during the election campaign. This language should be understood as a continuation of Abascal’s party strategy to conquer the political space of the traditional right, the “cowardly right wing”, as Vox usually refers to its closest political rivals (Ferreira 2019). However, as Figure 3 shows, the Catalan nationalist and left-wing parties were the main targets of Vox’s communication strategy.

The attribute “red” (14), which we added to the thesaurus compiled for this research, was used semantically as a synonym for “coup-mongering”, and, in turn, is closely related to terms such as “criminal” (42) and “Catalan” (228), “Socialist” (19) and “separatist” (Figure 3). The latter term is indisputably the one with the most negative connotations. As I

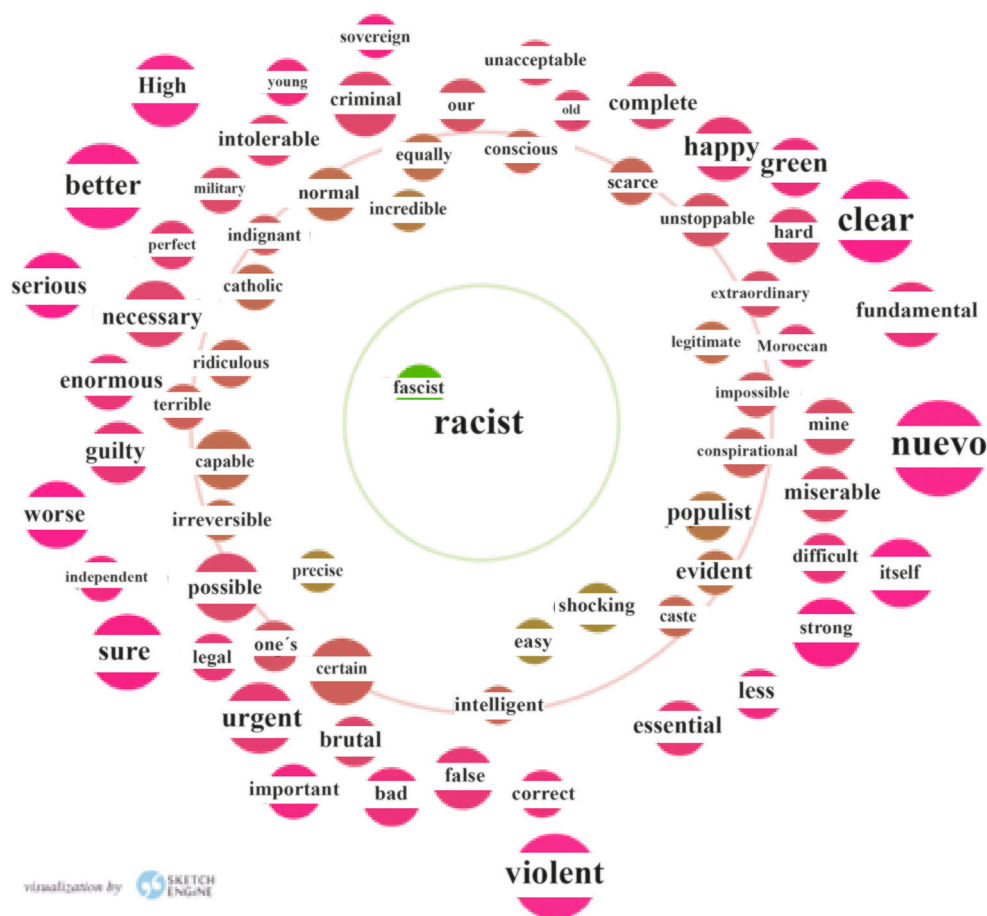


Figure 7. Semantic coincidence and relations between terms based on “racist”. Note: Source: Sketch Engine.

reached the square, a fanatic bellowed “Visca Catalunya lliure” [Long live free Catalonia], and I replied: “Yes, long live a Catalonia free of terrorists, separatists and totalitarians, and long live Spain forever”: a retweet by a Vox Party MP Carla Toscano of Santiago Abascal’s tweet See also Figures 4 and 5.

Besides appearing together with the epithet *progre*, tweets including references to separatism were linked to violent (93), totalitarian (66), and even terrorist (37) behaviour, as shown in Figures 4 and 5 and the campaign messages themselves: “Catalonia is threatened by the *progre* and separatist elites seeking to enforce a failed multiculturalist model on us. We will defend Catalonia, our identity, our tradition and our culture”, tweeted by Alberto Tarradas Paneque, who was running as a Vox candidate for the parliamentary seat of Gerona, on 29 January (Tarradas 2021). “Objects used by violent and totalitarian radicals of the extreme left, the partners of this #SocialCommunist Government to attack our comrades, sympathisers and affiliates who cannot conduct their Catalan election campaign in freedom”, denounced the Vox party MP Rafael Lomana one week later (Lomana 2021).

As Figure 6 shows, “coup-mongering” acquires a meaning similar to “delinquent”, “criminal”, and “separatist”, and “Catalan”, corroborated by the posts tweeted over the election campaign: “Out of foolishness or cowardice, many politicians remain silent. Others, like those in Sánchez’s government or those in the coup-mongering Catalan government, directly incite violence. But neither spineless silence nor futile hatred will stop our steadfast resolve to restore freedom to Catalonia” (Abascal 2021).

Finally, it is relevant to consider the semantic coincidence of the tweets according to other distinctly political-ideological terms, such as “fascist” or “racist”. In this case, (Figure 7), the associations are less apparent, making the messages more complex to interpret. Nevertheless, we identified a high degree of terminological and semantic relations between the two words, perhaps because they appeared together in the same tweet.²⁷

Thus, our results show that Vox’s election campaign harnessed hostility towards its political opponents and hatred towards other ideologies as a communicative resource.

Conclusions

The communication strategy focused on driving polarisation that was irrational and lacking in debateable arguments. Moreover, it was a campaign of messages, not leaders. These compelling and reiterative tweets, which tow the party line, revolved around disseminating a hostile discourse towards “the others”, using, for example, terms closely related to discriminating against or attacking other collectives or ideological groups.

It is worth noting that the messages attacking and denigrating “the others”, other political groups or ideologies, eventually led to disseminating hate speech towards people or groups defending ideologies other than those espoused by Vox. The vilification of the political opponent or the bearing of malice were the primary semantic constructs used in this offensive discourse, developed through the recurrent use of such epithets as coup-mongering, separatist, delinquent, red, *progre* or violent. In terms of the subject matter, references to the “recovery” of Catalonia stood out. Nationalistically speaking, Vox portrays itself as the saviour of Catalonia, with a mission to rid the Spanish region of immigrants - and the parties supporting them - as well as the *progre*, separatist and feminist ideologies, among others.

The study of far-right hate speech on social media, particularly in the Spanish context, has usually focused on attacks on people or vulnerable groups due to their race, sex, religion, and so on. However, this paper reveals how Vox’s anti-social discourse, which sought to offend its political opponents during an election campaign, ultimately generates an undemocratic environment that turns the political opponent into an enemy and drives social polarisation and hate speech towards individuals who defend other ideologies or parties.

Notes

1. The follow unfollow technique is used to gain followers on social networks and consists of following a massive number of accounts so that a proportion of them follow you back. Once the follow is achieved by the other user, the follow is unfollowed.

2. Vox MP for Cordoba.
3. Vox MP for Badajoz.
4. Vox Spokesperson in the Congress of Deputies and Deputy Foreign Affairs.
5. Deputy Spokesperson and Secretary General of Vox in the Congress of Deputies.
6. Vox MP for Valencia.
7. See Sociological Research Centre survey at: http://datos.cis.es/pdf/3309_Estimacion.pdf (last accessed: 04/03/2021).
8. This phenomenon did not occur in other regional elections (Aladro-Vico and Requeijo-Rey 2020, 215), so the publication of this poll was a decisive factor in their social media communication strategy.
9. "Let's take back Catalonia", or "Let's recover Catalonia".
10. "Only Vox is left".
11. "Only Vox".
12. "Vox extreme necessity".
13. "Now you have Vox".
14. "Progre", an abbreviation of "progresista". Vox uses this term in a pejorative sense to suggest a person who fervently engages in arguments on social justice, often in a shallow or not well-thought-out way, in order to raise their own personal reputation. Equivalents in English include "social justice warrior" (SJW), the "Twitter lynch mob", among many others.
15. The term "podemita" is used pejoratively by Vox to identify followers of Unidas Podemos party [the United We Can party].
16. Journalism for *progres*.
17. The term "caste", popularised by Unidas Podemos, denotes "a closed and inbred group that has turned corruption into a system of government to further their interests" (Criado-Aguilera 2017, 69). Vox uses this term as a weapon, since for them it is precisely the members of that left-wing party who enjoy privileges compared to the rest of the citizens. The hashtag reads: "The caste at the cost of your dosh".
18. The hashtag reads "Enough of *progre* censorship" For Vox, the concept "*progre*" encapsulates different social, media and political actors who identify the most negative aspects of politics. Constant references are made in Vox's messages to the social distance dividing the political vision of these actors and that of the party. (Cheddadi 2020, 65).
19. "Wretched little right wing"
20. "You don't choose your sex"
21. Cruz, Marisa. 26/02/2021. «La Junta Electoral segunda la suspensión de la cuenta de Vox en Twitter por incitar al odio». *El Mundo*. Available at :<https://www.elmundo.es/espana/2021/02/26/603902a121efa07f018b4673.html> (last consulted: 05/03/2021)
22. The political party Vox considers that the Popular Party does not apply programmes more identifiable with conservatism because of cowardice. For this reason, it recurrently uses the adjective "cowardly right-wing" to refer to them.
23. The Vox party and its followers recurrently use this name to refer to Pablo Iglesias, founder of the Podemos party, because of his ponytail hairstyle.
24. Paxton points out that there is a number of "mobilizing passions" characterising fascism. Among them, he highlights "the belief that the ones' group is a victim, a sentiment that justifies any action, without legal or moral limits, against its enemies, both internal and external its enemies", such as secessionists, feminists, immigrants, among others (2004, 79).
25. From this point on, and unless otherwise specified, the figures in parentheses refer to the frequency with which a term appeared in the set of analysed tweets.
26. In January 2021, the young people's roundtable TV show GenPlayz hosted a debate entitled "Are we living in a *progre* dictatorship?" In it, various young people began by discussing the meaning of the term "*progre*". One of debaters remarked: "I've used *progre* as an insult [...] Does it really mean anything right now? I don't think so. It's simply used to ridicule". Another person added: "I understand *progre* as an insult given to people who are more to the left of the ideas" (RTVE 2021). Evidence of the pejorative connotations attributed to this term.

27. For instance, the example of Carla Toscano and her tweet of 7 February: “The hatred and violence against @vox_es is not spontaneous. It has been fabricated and orchestrated by political parties and journalists demonizing us, calling us batasunos, terrorists, fascists, racists and chauvinists” (Toscano 2021).
28. Note: Ignacio Garriga Vaz de Concicao (@lgarrigavaz) is part of both groups, since he was the Vox candidate for the Presidency of the Generalitat without abandoning his seat as a Spanish MP.
29. Sketch Engine graphics have been configured by this program from its Thesaurus tool. The latter automatically generates synonyms or words belonging to the same category (semantic field). The closer a word appears to the central term, the more similarity is seen between the two or the more characteristics they share. The size of the word corresponds to the frequency, i.e. the number of times it appears in the text. The colors simply illustrate the different grammatical category (verb, noun, adverb, adjective).

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Annexe 1: Study sample and main details of their Twitter profiles (updated 27 January 2021)

Name	Account	Followers	Following	Lists	Sample stratum
Abascal Conde, Santiago	@Santi_ABASCAL	553709	3934	2162	National MPs
Espinosa de los Monteros de Simón, Iván	@ivanedlm	293187	3720	963	
Olona Choclán, Macarena	@Macarena_Olona	253539	1395	655	Candidates for the Generalitat of Catalonia
Ortega Smith-Molina, Francisco Javier	@Ortega_Smith	198071	462	758	
Garriga Vaz de Concicao, Ignacio ²⁸	@lgarrigavaz	89168	1854	357	
Toscano de Balbín, Carla	@eledhmel	83904	5945	322	
Sánchez del Real, Víctor Manuel	@sanchezdelreal	75448	5172	479	
Rosety Fernández de Castro, Agustín	@AgustinRosety	57212	2734	228	
Alcaraz Martos, Francisco José	@fjosealcaraz	45787	1398	252	
Borrás Pabón, Mireia	@_mireiaborras	42407	516	136	
De Meer Méndez, Rocío	@MeerRocio	37013	1087	193	
Mariscal Zabala, Manuel	@MariscalZabala	32429	1829	280	
Fernández Hernández, Pedro	@pedro_fhz	30625	7755	137	
Romero Vilches, María de los Reyes	@rromerovilches	19718	1314	132	
Mestre Barea, Manuel	@mestremmanuel	17885	371	106	
Fernández-Lomana Gutiérrez, Rafael	@RafaLomana	16831	782	116	
Contreras Peláez, Francisco José	@fjconpe	14189	506	139	
Sáez Alonso-Muñumer, Pablo	@PabloSaezAM	17432	3995	127	
Rueda Perelló, Patricia	@_patricia_rueda	13201	1171	149	
Esteban Calonje, Cristina Alicia	@CrisEstebanVox	12616	1069	76	
Ramírez del Río, José	@joseramirezdel2	13298	2895	78	
González Coello de Portugal, Víctor	@vicpiedra	11137	996	83	
Ruiz Solás, María de la Cabeza	@RuizSolas	10214	104	102	
Mónica Lora Cisquer	@MonicaLora_	7932	805	37	
Antonio Gallego Burgos	@AntonioGalleg0	4610	854	8	
Juan de la Cruz Garriga Dómenec	@JGarrigaDomenec	2802	975	21	
María Elisa García Fuster	@MariaEGarciaFu2	2053	730	1	
José Manuel Arias Flores	@JoseM_Arias	727	291	9	
Isabel Melendez Valdés Romero	@isamelen1	611	189	0	
Sergio López González	@SergioLopezVox	2585	2336	3	
Alberto Tarradas Paneque	@AlbertoTPaneque	21096	667	86	
Sergi Fabri Llaveró	@SergiFabri	4452	1541	20	
Ignasi Mulleras Vinzia	@IgnasiMulleras	2551	669	3	
Vanesa Guaita Granado	@GuaitaVanesa	803	281	2	
Antonio Ramón López Gómez	@tonilopez_Vox	1421	180	0	
Isabel Lázaro Pina	@IsabelLazaro_	1447	269	5	
Sergio Macián de Greef	@sergio_macian	535	626	2	